Meanwhile, even before the first phase of the drive kicked off, the government had begun to plan the second phase of inoculating those over the age of 50 and those with comorbidities over the age of 35. An important part of the planning was the need to set up a robust digital backbone for it. The government planned to introduce an app which would have four modules: user administrator module, beneficiary registration, vaccination and beneficiary acknowledgement and status update features. The app would be called CoWIN (COVID Vaccine Intelligence Network). It would be able to automate allocation of the vaccination session by using the Aadhaar number, send out SMS reminders of vaccination appointments and QR Code-enabled digital certificates. Although the general public would only be able to self-register once the vaccination drive opened up for Phase II, for Phase I, the CoWIN ecosystem would already have in its database the entire list of the Phase I recipients.

In early January, Cabinet Secretary Gauba telephoned Ram Sewak Sharma, who had now retired from the civil services after over five decades to come in for a meeting with PM Modi. The prime minister had asked him to come on-board to help build CoWIN, perhaps as a follow-up to the presentation that Sharma had made to him back in June 2020, in addition to his contributing role in NEGVAC—a job that Sharma was thrilled to take up. While in NEGVAC, Sharma was instrumental in leading the process of converting eVIN to CoWIN. On the same day, the Empowered Group on Vaccine Administration, with him as a convener, was created in order to ensure that necessary decisions could be made swiftly without any process hold-ups. On 14 January, in the meeting with the prime minister, the PM reiterated to him that a solid, secure and highly efficient product would have to be created. Encouraged by the boost, tech experts and developers got together under a team led by Sharma, to create a platform which would go on to become the backbone of the largest vaccination drive in the world. One of the primary concerns was the security of the data. This platform would be used by every single Indian which would mean that their details would be available on the platform, making it absolutely essential to protect the data. Hence, the team concluded that the platform would have to be built on the principles of ‘privacy by design’.[14] This design feature would entail that only the bare minimum relevant data from each individual would be collected, that no data would be used without consent of the individuals, the use of the data would be limited to the specific purpose for which it was